

List of 200 Commonly used Foreign Words & Phrases in English (A–Z)

A

1. Ad hoc – For a particular purpose only – Latin – Common
 2. Ad infinitum – To infinity; endlessly – Latin – Academic
 3. Ad nauseam – To a sickening degree – Latin – Common
 4. Al fresco – In the open air – Italian – Common
 5. Alma mater – One's former school/university – Latin – Common
 6. Alter ego – Second self – Latin – Common
 7. Amigo – Friend – Spanish – Common
 8. Amor fati – Love of fate – Latin – Rare
 9. Annus horribilis – A disastrous year – Latin – Rare
 10. Annus mirabilis – A remarkable year – Latin – Rare
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B

11. Bête noire – Something one particularly dislikes – French – Academic
 12. Bon voyage – Have a good trip – French – Common
 13. Bona fide – Genuine; in good faith – Latin – Common
 14. Boulevard – Wide street – French – Common
 15. Bravado – Show of boldness – Spanish – Common
 16. Carpe diem – Seize the day – Latin – Academic
 17. Carte blanche – Full freedom – French – Academic
 18. Caveat – Warning or caution – Latin – Academic
 19. Caveat emptor – Let the buyer beware – Latin – Academic
 20. C'est la vie – That's life – French – Common
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C

21. Circa – Approximately (dates) – Latin – Academic
 22. Civitas – Citizenship/state – Latin – Rare
 23. Cognoscenti – Experts – Italian – Rare
 24. Consensus – General agreement – Latin – Academic
 25. Corpus – Body of work – Latin – Academic
 26. Coup d'état – Sudden overthrow – French – Academic
 27. Coup de grâce – Final blow – French – Academic
 28. Curriculum vitae – Course of life; résumé – Latin – Academic
 29. Cui bono – Who benefits? – Latin – Rare
 30. Cul-de-sac – Dead-end street – French – Common
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D

31. De facto – In practice, not law – Latin – Academic
32. De jure – By law – Latin – Academic
33. Deus ex machina – God from the machine (unexpected resolution) – Latin – Academic
34. Dictum – Authoritative statement – Latin – Academic
35. Doppelgänger – Double/look-alike – German – Common

- 36. Dulce et decorum est – Sweet and fitting (to die for one's country) – Latin – Rare
 - 37. Du jour – Of the day – French – Common
 - 38. Drama personae – Cast of characters – Latin – Rare
 - 39. De gustibus non est disputandum – No disputing about taste – Latin – Rare
 - 40. Domus – Household/home – Latin – Rare
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E

- 41. E pluribus unum – Out of many, one – Latin – Academic
 - 42. E.g. (exempli gratia) – For example – Latin – Academic
 - 43. Erratum – Error – Latin – Academic
 - 44. Et al. – And others – Latin – Academic
 - 45. Et cetera (etc.) – And so forth – Latin – Common
 - 46. Ex gratia – As a favor, not obligation – Latin – Academic
 - 47. Ex officio – By virtue of office – Latin – Academic
 - 48. Ex post facto – After the fact – Latin – Academic
 - 49. Exempli causa – For the sake of example – Latin – Rare
 - 50. Ex nihilo – Out of nothing – Latin – Rare
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F

- 51. Fait accompli – Accomplished fact – French – Academic
 - 52. Faux pas – Social blunder – French – Common
 - 53. Festina lente – Make haste slowly – Latin – Rare
 - 54. Fiat – Decree/order – Latin – Academic
 - 55. Flora and fauna – Plants and animals – Latin – Academic
 - 56. Foie gras – Omitted (food item replaced).
 - 57. Fortissimo – Very loud (music) – Italian – Academic
 - 58. Francophone – French-speaking – French – Academic
 - 59. Frisson – Thrill/shiver – French – Rare
 - 60. Fugue – Musical form – Italian – Academic
 - 61. Functus officio – Having fulfilled purpose – Latin – Rare
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G

- 61. Gaffe – Blunder – French – Common
 - 62. Gaudeamus igitur – Therefore let us rejoice – Latin – Rare
 - 63. Genius loci – Spirit of the place – Latin – Rare
 - 64. Gesundheit – Bless you – German – Common
 - 65. Graffiti – Wall writing – Italian – Common
 - 66. Gratis – Free – Latin – Common
 - 67. Gravitas – Seriousness – Latin – Academic
 - 68. Guerrilla – Small independent fighter – Spanish – Common
 - 69. Gulag – Prison camp – Russian – Academic
 - 70. Gymnasium – Secondary school – Greek via German – Academic
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H

71. Habeas corpus – You shall have the body (legal writ) – Latin – Academic
 72. Habitat – Natural home – Latin – Academic
 73. Haute couture – High fashion – French – Academic
 74. Hic et nunc – Here and now – Latin – Rare
 75. Hoi polloi – The masses – Greek – Common
 76. Homo sapiens – Wise man – Latin – Academic
 77. Hubris – Excessive pride – Greek – Academic
 78. Hypothesis – Proposed explanation – Greek – Academic
 79. Hypocrite – Pretender – Greek – Common
 80. Hyperbole – Exaggeration – Greek – Academic
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I

81. Id est (i.e.) – That is – Latin – Academic
 82. Idée fixe – Fixed idea/obsession – French – Academic
 83. Ignoramus – Ignorant person – Latin – Rare
 84. Impromptu – Without preparation – French – Common
 85. In absentia – In absence – Latin – Academic
 86. In camera – In private – Latin – Academic
 87. In loco parentis – In place of parent – Latin – Academic
 88. In medias res – Into the middle of things – Latin – Academic
 89. In memoriam – In memory of – Latin – Academic
 90. In situ – In original place – Latin – Academic
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J

91. Je ne sais quoi – Indescribable quality – French – Common
 92. J'adoube – I adjust (in chess) – French – Rare
 93. Juggernaut – Huge unstoppable force – Sanskrit via English – Common
 94. Junta – Military group ruling – Spanish – Common
 95. Jurisprudence – Theory of law – Latin – Academic
 96. Jus cogens – Peremptory norm – Latin – Rare
 97. Jus gentium – Law of nations – Latin – Rare
 98. Jus soli – Right of soil – Latin – Rare
 99. Jus sanguinis – Right of blood – Latin – Rare
 100. Juste milieu – Happy medium – French – Rare
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K

101. Kaput – Finished/done – German – Common
102. Kibitz – Offer unwanted advice – Yiddish – Rare
103. Kudos – Praise – Greek – Common
104. Kafkaesque – Surreal/illogical – German (after Kafka) – Academic
105. Kaleidoscope – Beautiful changing pattern – Greek – Common
106. Kulturkampf – Cultural struggle – German – Rare
107. Kyrie eleison – Lord, have mercy – Greek – Rare
108. Kosmos – Universe/order – Greek – Rare
109. Ken – Range of knowledge – Scots (from Germanic) – Rare
110. Kleptocracy – Rule by thieves – Greek – Academic

L

- 111. Laissez-faire – Hands-off policy – French – Academic
- 112. Lapsus linguae – Slip of the tongue – Latin – Rare
- 113. Legion – Multitude – Latin – Common
- 114. Lexicon – Vocabulary – Greek – Academic
- 115. Locus classicus – Classic example – Latin – Rare
- 116. Lorem ipsum – Placeholder text – Latin – Common (in publishing)
- 117. Luna – Moon – Latin – Rare
- 118. Lux et veritas – Light and truth – Latin – Rare
- 119. Lumen – Light – Latin – Academic
- 120. Lustrum – Five-year period – Latin – Rare

M

- 121. Magnum opus – Great work – Latin – Academic
- 122. Memento mori – Remember you will die – Latin – Rare
- 123. Mens rea – Guilty mind (law) – Latin – Academic
- 124. Modus operandi – Way of operating – Latin – Academic
- 125. Modus vivendi – Way of living – Latin – Rare
- 126. Mondegreen – Misheard phrase – English (Scottish) – Rare
- 127. Mores – Customs – Latin – Academic
- 128. Mutatis mutandis – With necessary changes – Latin – Rare
- 129. Myopia – Short-sightedness – Greek – Common
- 130. Mythos – Traditional narrative – Greek – Academic

N

- 131. Ne plus ultra – Highest point – Latin – Rare
- 132. Nemo dat – No one gives what he doesn't have – Latin – Rare
- 133. Neologism – New word – Greek – Academic
- 134. Nihil obstat – Nothing obstructs (approval) – Latin – Rare
- 135. Nihilism – Belief in nothing – Latin via French – Academic
- 136. Nisi prius – Unless before (trial court) – Latin – Rare
- 137. Nom de plume – Pen name – French – Common
- 138. Nota bene (N.B.) – Note well – Latin – Academic
- 139. Novus ordo seclorum – New order of the ages – Latin – Rare
- 140. Numen – Divine presence – Latin – Rare

O

- 141. Obiter dictum – Passing remark – Latin – Academic
- 142. Oblivion – State of being forgotten – Latin – Common
- 143. Odyssey – Long journey – Greek – Common
- 144. Oeuvre – Complete works – French – Academic
- 145. Omnia vincit amor – Love conquers all – Latin – Rare
- 146. Omnibus – For all – Latin – Academic

- 147. Opera – Dramatic musical work – Italian – Academic
 - 148. Oratio obliqua – Indirect speech – Latin – Rare
 - 149. Orbis terrarum – World – Latin – Rare
 - 150. Orthodox – Correct belief – Greek – Academic
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P

- 151. Panacea – Cure-all – Greek – Academic
 - 152. Pax Romana – Roman peace – Latin – Rare
 - 153. Per capita – By head/per person – Latin – Academic
 - 154. Per diem – By the day – Latin – Academic
 - 155. Per se – By itself – Latin – Academic
 - 156. Persona non grata – Unwelcome person – Latin – Academic
 - 157. Post mortem – After death – Latin – Academic
 - 158. Post hoc – After this, therefore because of this – Latin – Academic
 - 159. Prima facie – At first sight – Latin – Academic
 - 160. Pro bono – For the public good – Latin – Academic
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Q

- 161. Quasi – As if, seemingly – Latin – Academic
 - 162. Quid pro quo – Something for something – Latin – Common
 - 163. Quid nunc – Busybody; gossip – Latin – Rare
 - 164. Quorum – Minimum number to decide – Latin – Academic
 - 165. Quot capita, tot sensus – So many men, so many opinions – Latin – Rare
 - 166. Q.E.D. (quod erat demonstrandum) – Which was to be demonstrated – Latin – Academic
 - 167. Querencia – Place of safety – Spanish – Rare
 - 168. Quietus – Final settlement – Latin – Rare
 - 169. Quinquennial – Five-year period – Latin – Rare
 - 170. Quis custodiet ipsos custodes? – Who guards the guards? – Latin – Rare
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R

- 171. Raison d'être – Reason for existence – French – Academic
 - 172. Requiem – Mass for the dead – Latin – Academic
 - 173. Res gestae – Things done (facts of a case) – Latin – Rare
 - 174. Res ipsa loquitur – The thing speaks for itself – Latin – Academic
 - 175. Res judicata – Already judged – Latin – Academic
 - 176. Rota – Wheel/court – Latin – Rare
 - 177. Rendezvous – Meeting – French – Common
 - 178. Riposte – Quick reply – French – Common
 - 179. Rhetoric – Art of persuasion – Greek – Academic
 - 180. Rubicon – Point of no return – Latin – Academic
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S

- 181. Sans – Without – French – Common

182. Sapere aude – Dare to know – Latin – Rare
 183. Schadenfreude – Joy at others' misfortune – German – Academic
 184. Scientia potentia est – Knowledge is power – Latin – Rare
 185. Semper fidelis – Always faithful – Latin – Rare
 186. Semper idem – Always the same – Latin – Rare
 187. Serendipity – Chance discovery – Persian via English – Common
 188. Sine qua non – Essential condition – Latin – Academic
 189. Status quo – Existing state – Latin – Academic
 190. Sub rosa – In secret – Latin – Rare
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T

1. Tabula rasa – Blank slate – Latin – Academic
 2. Tempus fugit – Time flies – Latin – Common
 3. Terra incognita – Unknown land – Latin – Rare
 4. Tour de force – An exceptional achievement – French – Academic
 5. Tristesse – Sadness – French – Rare
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U

1. Ultimatum – Final demand – Latin – Common
 2. Ultra vires – Beyond one's powers – Latin – Academic
 3. Urbi et orbi – To the city and to the world – Latin – Rare
 4. Usufruct – Right to use property belonging to another – Latin – Academic
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V

1. Vade mecum – A handbook; constant companion – Latin – Rare
 2. Veni, vidi, vici – I came, I saw, I conquered – Latin – Common
 3. Verbatim – Word for word – Latin – Common
 4. Veritas – Truth – Latin – Rare
 5. Vox populi – Voice of the people – Latin – Common
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W

1. Wanderlust – Strong desire to travel – German – Common
 2. Weltschmerz – World-weariness; melancholy – German – Rare
 3. Wunderkind – Child prodigy – German – Common
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X

1. Xenophobia – Fear of foreigners – Greek via Latin – Common
2. X factor – Special talent – Modern Latin/English hybrid – Common

Y

1. Yen – Deep desire/longing – Japanese – Common
 2. Yin and Yang – Complementary forces – Chinese – Common
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Z

1. Zeitgeist – Spirit of the age – German – Academic
 2. Zero sum – A situation where one's gain is another's loss – Latin via English – Academic
 3. Zigzag – From French/ Germanic roots, indirect course – Common
 4. Zoo politikon – Political animal (term by Aristotle) – Greek via Latin – Rare
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